

## ★ comfort

- ✗ This chair is not very **comfort**.  
 ✗ This chair is not very **comfortable**.  
 'Comfort' is a noun or verb but the adjective is 'comfortable'.

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## commonly believed

- ✗ It is **commonly believed** that Cantonese is the main language of Hong Kong.  
 ✓ Cantonese **is** the main language of Hong Kong.  
 'It is commonly believed' should not be used for something that is certainly true. There must be some doubt – some people who don't believe it:  
 ✓ It is **commonly believed** that smoking is bad for your health.

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## communication(s)

- ✗ In Hong Kong **communications** are very bad in rush hours.  
 ✓ In Hong Kong **traffic** is very bad in rush hours.  
 ✗ The **communication** between Central and Wan Chai is very good.  
 ✓ **Transport** between Central and Wanchai is very good.  
 The Cantonese 交通 covers different English meanings of 'communications', 'traffic' and 'transport'.  
 'Communications' usually means letters, phone calls, telegrams etc. It can include roads, transport etc in the broader sense but should never be used when **only** transport is meant. See also TRAFFIC.

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## company

- ✗ I bought some bread from a **company** in Hung Hom.  
 ✓ I bought some bread from a **shop** in Hung Hom.  
 Although 公司 can be used for 'shop' as well as 'company' in Cantonese, 'company' in English means a business in the legal sense, not a shop.

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## concert

- 2 ✗ That's not important; don't **concern** about it.  
 ✓ That's not important; don't **worry** about it.  
 The verb here would have to be 'concern yourself', but 'worry' is simpler.

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## ★ conclusion

- ✗ As a **conclusion**, I want to thank everybody who helped make this exhibition such a success.  
 ✓ In **conclusion**, I want to thank everybody who helped make this exhibition such a success.

349

## conclusively

- ✗ **Conclusively**, I ask you all to support the motion.  
 ✓ In **conclusion**, I ask you all to support the motion.  
 As with the previous entry, the fixed expression when coming to the end of a speech or essay is 'in conclusion'.  
 'Conclusively' means leaving no doubt:  
 ✓ She proved **conclusively** that Joe committed the crime.

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## condition

- 1 ✗ She lives in a crowded **condition**.  
 ✓ She lives in crowded **conditions**.  
 The singular 'condition' refers to the state somebody or something is in, e.g. the state of a person's health or fitness. The plural 'conditions' refers to the situation around somebody or the circumstances someone is in. It may be helpful to think of 'condition' as internal and 'conditions' as external.

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## ★ complain

- 1 ✗ Your **complaining** letter was received yesterday.

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- ✓ Your **letter of complaint** was received yesterday.  
 'Complaining' is normally used about a person.  
 2 ✗ They **complaint** that the radio didn't work.  
 ✓ They **complained** that the radio didn't work.  
 'Complaint' is a noun. The verb takes '-ed' in the simple past.  
 3 ✗ I want to **complain** the conditions here.  
 ✓ I want to **complain about** the conditions here.  
 One complains **to** someone **about** something.

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## ★ complicate

- ✗ It is a very **complicate** problem.  
 ✓ It is a very **complicated** problem.  
 'Complicate' is the verb. The adjective takes '-ed'.

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## ★ concern

- 1 ✗ The letter **concerns** about overcrowding.  
 ✓ The letter **concerns** overcrowding.  
 ✓ The letter **is about** overcrowding.  
 The verb 'concern' does not take 'about'. However, the adjective 'concerned' does:  
 ✓ She **is concerned about** overcrowding.



- 2 ✗ In my **condition**, with a young family, I can't take an evening job.  
 ✓ In my **situation**, with a young family, I can't take an evening job.  
 'Condition' here would have to refer to the person's health.

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## conscious

- 1 ✗ Something hit me and I lost my **conscious**.  
 ✓ Something hit me and I lost **consciousness**.  
 'Conscious' is an adjective, the noun is 'consciousness'.  
 2 ✗ I became dizzy and then I **felt** unconscious.  
 ✓ I became dizzy and then I **felt** unconscious.  
 The expression is 'to fall unconscious'.

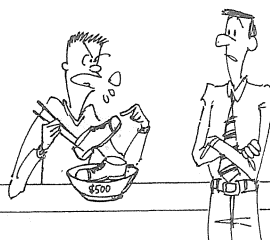
135

350

## consume

- ✗ If you don't lower the price I won't **consume** these shoes!

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## contact

- ✓ If you don't lower the price I won't buy these shoes!  
Although a 'consumer' is one who buys and uses things, the verb 'to consume' still has its original meaning of 'to eat'!
- 1 ✗ I shall ~~contact~~ with her about it. [238]  
✓ I shall **contact** her about it.  
The verb 'contact' takes a direct object but 'contact' as a noun is used in the expression 'to be in contact with':  
✓ I shall **be in contact** with her about it. [238]
- 2 ✗ As a child grows, she ~~contacts~~ many different people. [238]  
✓ As a child grows, she **comes into contact** with many different people.  
To 'contact' someone is to make a deliberate effort to communicate with him or her. To 'come into contact with' people is to meet them in the normal course of events, without making a special effort.

## convenience

- ✗ The MTR is very ~~convenience~~. [136]  
✓ The MTR is very **convenient**.  
'Convenience' is a noun. The adjective ends in 't'.

## cooker

- ✗ My mother is a good ~~cooker~~. [17]



## corner

- ✓ My mother is a good cook.  
A 'cooker' is an appliance for cooking, e.g. a stove, a rice-cooker etc. A person who cooks is simply a 'cook'.
- ✗ I went to the shoe ~~corner~~ of the department store. [18]  
✓ I went to the shoe **department** of the store.  
'Corner' is not used in this way. It should be 'department' in a big store or possibly 'counter' in a smaller store.

## cost

- ✗ It ~~cost~~ us only half an hour to get there. [348]  
✓ It **took** us only half an hour to get there.  
Although one **spends** both time and money, something **costs** money but **takes** time.

## criticise

- ✗ They ~~criticised~~ that TV has a harmful effect. [274]  
✓ They **criticised** TV **for having** a harmful effect.  
You criticise something or someone **for doing** something. 'Criticise' must have a noun as its object.

## crowded

- 1 ✗ It was a very ~~crowdy~~ place. [94]  
✓ It was a very **crowded** place.  
The adjective is 'crowded'. [218]
- 2 ✗ Mongkok is ~~crowded of~~ people. [319]  
✓ Mongkok is **crowded with** people.

## day

- ✗ That ~~day~~ morning we set off for Lantau. [319]  
✓ That **morning** we set off for Lantau.  
'Day' is not mentioned in expressions like 'one morning', 'that afternoon' etc.

## detail

- ✗ She presented a very ~~detail~~ proposal. [137]  
✓ She presented a very **detailed** proposal.  
'Detail' is a noun or verb; the adjective has '-ed'.

## department

- ✗ I bought my suit in a ~~department~~. [18]  
✓ I bought my suit in a **department store**.  
'Department' cannot be used on its own like this: it's only one section of a 'department store'.

## died

- ✗ They found him in the desert but he ~~was died~~. [158]  
✓ They found him in the desert but he **was dead**.  
✓ They found him in the desert but he **had died**.  
'Dead' is the adjective, 'died' is the simple past tense and past participle.

## difficult

- ✗ I am very ~~difficult~~ to go there. [294]  
✓ It is very **difficult for me** to go there.  
The Cantonese begins with 'I': 我去個處好麻煩; but the English must begin with 'It' because 'going there' is difficult (as in the Cantonese), not the person.

## discount

- ✗ The shoes were a little cheaper with a 90% ~~discount~~. [90]  
✓ The shoes were a little cheaper with a 10% **discount**.  
This is expressed in opposite ways in Cantonese and English: the percentage **to pay** in Cantonese and the percentage **off** in English. So 八折 is a 20% discount.

## discuss

- ✗ At the meeting they ~~discussed~~ about the problem. [239]  
✓ At the meeting they **discussed** the problem.  
✓ At the meeting they **talked about** the problem.  
To 'discuss' is to 'talk about', so it does not take 'about'.

## doubt

- ✗ It is no ~~doubt~~ that she will do well. [290]  
✓ **There is no doubt** that she will do well.  
In this sort of sentence, 'it is' should be followed by an adjective, e.g. 'it is certain', but a noun like 'doubt' should

## drama

- ✗ We went to the theatre to see a ~~drama~~. [64]  
✓ We went to the theatre to see a **play**.  
Drama' is the general word for theatrical writings; a particular one is called a 'play'.

## due to

- ✗ ~~Due to~~ this reason, they sold the business. [337]  
✓ **For** this reason they sold the business.  
✓ The sale of the business was **due to** poor profits.  
'Due to' means 'caused by', so it does not need the similar idea of 'reason'. See also REASON.

## dull

- ✗ I had nothing to do, so I was very ~~dull~~. [19]  
✓ I had nothing to do, so I was very **bored**.  
'Dull' means 'uninteresting'. Like 'boring', when a film, speech etc is 'dull' it makes you 'bored'. When 'dull' is applied to a person, it means 'slow to understand':  
✓ He is rather **dull** and seldom passes any tests.

## each

- 1 ✗ ~~Each of the students~~ were afraid. [194]  
✓ **Each of the students** **was** afraid.  
'Each' takes a singular verb (each one) while 'all' takes a plural verb with countable nouns:  
✓ **All of the students** **were** afraid.  
2 ✗ Almost ~~each~~ family has television now. [179]  
✓ Almost **every** family has television now.  
'Every' also takes a singular verb but focuses on the whole group, while 'each' focuses on the individual.  
3 ✗ These apples are \$2 ~~each~~. [219]  
✓ These apples are \$2 **each**.

## economical

- ✗ The government has had ~~economical~~ problems this year. [20]  
✓ The government has had **economic** problems this year.  
'Economic' means 'concerning the economy'.

- ✓ 'Economical' means 'not wasting money'.  
 ✓ She is very **economical** with purchases and saves us a lot of money.

# emphasise

- ✗ He emphasised ~~on~~ the importance of planning. [240]  
 ✓ He **emphasised** the importance of planning.  
 'Emphasise' does not take 'on'.

# entertainment

- ✗ After dinner there ~~were~~ some entertainments. [173]  
 ✓ After dinner there **was** some **entertainment**.  
 'Entertainment' is, in most cases, uncountable, so cannot be plural.

# entry

- ✗ Many good students can't ~~entry~~ university in Hong Kong. [138]  
 ✓ Many good students can't **enter** university in Hong Kong.  
 'Entry' is the noun; the verb is 'enter'.

# equipment

- ✗ A lot of ~~equipments~~ are needed for science classes. [164]  
 ✓ A lot of **equipment** is needed for science classes.  
 'Equipment' is uncountable, so cannot be plural.

# etc

- ✗ We sell home appliances like refrigerators, washing machines, stoves ~~and etc~~. [341]  
 ✓ We sell home appliances like refrigerators, washing machines, stoves, **etc**.  
 'Et cetera' (etc) means 'and so on', so should not have 'and' in front of it.

# even

- ✗ ~~Even~~, they had tickets, they still couldn't get into the concert. [340]  
 ✓ **Even though** they had tickets, they still couldn't get into the concert.  
 'Even' must be followed by 'though/if/when' depending on the context:  
 ✓ **Even if** I had brought an umbrella, I

# every

- ✓ still would have got wet.  
 ✓ **Even when** he was an old man, he went for a daily run.
- 1 ✗ Every passengers were frightened. [195]  
 ✓ **Every passenger** was frightened.  
 ✓ The prices are low for every goods.  
 ✓ The prices are low for **all goods**.  
 'Every' takes a singular noun and verb; 'all' takes plural ones with countable nouns.
- 2 ✗ Every one of us could ~~not~~ go to sleep. [313]  
 ✓ **None of us could** go to sleep.  
 'Every' should not be used with a negative verb. Use 'none' with a positive verb.

# every day

- ✗ Paul listens to music ~~everyday~~. [104]  
 ✓ Paul listens to music **every day**.  
 'Every day' is two words on most occasions it is used: i.e. telling when something happens.  
 'Everyday' is one word **only** when it is an adjective:  
 ✓ She didn't wear anything special, just her **everyday clothes**.

# every time

- 1 ✗ Everytime I hear that music I feel sad. [106]  
 ✓ **Every time** I hear that music I feel sad.  
 'Every time' is never one word.
- 2 ✗ Every time ~~when~~ we go to a cinema, I buy popcorn. [341]  
 ✓ **Every time we go** to a cinema, I buy popcorn.  
 'When' is unnecessary with 'every time'.

# everybody

- ✗ Everybody were frightened when the lights went out. [196]  
 ✓ **Everybody was** frightened when the lights went out.  
 'Everybody' takes a singular verb.

# everyone

- 1 ✗ Everyone are happy with the pay rise. [197]  
 ✓ **Everyone is** happy with the pay rise.  
 'Everyone' takes singular verb.
- 2 ✗ Everyone of the children won a prize. [105]

- ✓ **Every one of** the children won a prize.  
 When followed by 'of + noun/pronoun', 'every one' must be two words.

# everywhere

- ✗ You can get off a mini-bus ~~everywhere~~ you want. [317]  
 ✓ You can get off a mini-bus **anywhere** you want.  
 It would be impossible on one trip to get off at all places (everywhere) but one can get off at any one place no matter where it is (anywhere).

# evidence

- 1 ✗ There are evidences that Mr Brown took the money. [165]  
 ✓ There **is evidence** that Mr Brown took the money.  
 'Evidence' is uncountable, so cannot be plural.
- 2 ✗ One good evidence is that he has been spending much more than usual recently. [166]  
 ✓ One good **piece of evidence** is that he has been spending much more than usual recently.  
 'Pieces of evidence' are countable, but not 'evidence'.

# excited

- 1 ✗ It was an ~~excited~~ match and we won by one point. [213]  
 ✓ It was an **exciting** match and we won by one point.  
 'Excited' means feeling excitement but 'exciting' means making people excited. So the match is 'exciting' and the spectators 'excited'.
- 2 ✗ I felt very ~~exciting~~ when I was chosen for the school team. [213]  
 ✓ I felt very **excited** when I was chosen for the school team.
- 3 ✗ My sister fell down unconscious, so I was very excited. [21]  
 ✓ My sister fell down unconscious, so I was very **worried**.  
 The most common meaning of 'excited' concerns good feelings, so it's better to use a word like 'worried' or 'agitated' here.

# exhausted

- ✗ Exhausted gases cause a lot of pollution. [58]



- ✓ **Exhaust** gases cause a lot of pollution.  
 'Exhausted' means 'extremely tired' but 'exhaust' is a noun for unwanted gases that escape from an engine.

# expensive

- ✗ The taxi fare is quite expensive. [66]  
 ✓ The taxi fare is quite **high**.  
 Goods and services can be 'expensive/cheap' but prices/fares/costs/bills etc are 'high/low'.

# express

- ✗ She likes to ~~express~~ out her opinion. [241]  
 ✓ She likes to **express** her opinion.  
 'Out' is not used so much after verbs in English as 出 is in Cantonese, e.g. 表示出 or 講出.

# facilitate

- 1 ✗ The MTR facilitates people. [22]  
 ✓ The MTR **facilitates** travelling to work.  
 People cannot be 'facilitated'; it means 'making things easier'.
- 2 ✗ The caretakers facilitate the residents. [53]  
 ✓ The caretakers **serve** the residents.

# family

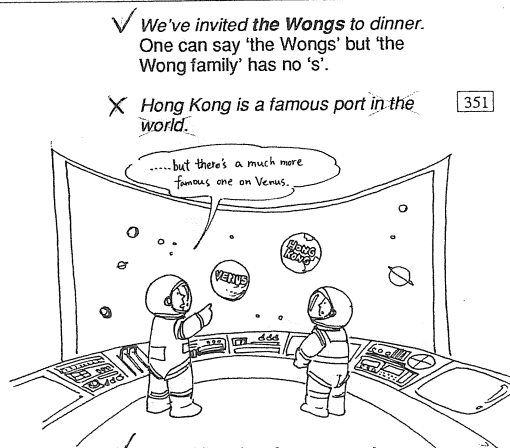
- ✗ We've invited the Wohgs family to dinner. [198]  
 ✓ We've invited **the Wong family** to dinner.

**Proofreading:** In each of the following questions, there is one or no mistake. For each question, you may underline one word and write another word above it to replace it; or put a ^ between two words and write down an additional word above the ^; or cross out one redundant word. If there is no mistake, put a ✓ on the far right.

1. This social worker concerned about the poor boy whose father died in a traffic accident last night.
2. To Thomas, solving those complicate mathematical problems is his everyday task.
3. In this details report, the scientist emphasizes the importance of stopping global warming.
4. Despite the comfort that the hotel offers, he still complained about the poor attitude of the staff there.
5. Everyone agrees that travelling on the MTR is convenient but dull.
6. The company spent a lot of money buying equipments. They bought printers, computers, and etc.
7. The ladies are discussing about the expensive handbag that Mary has just bought.

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famous



✓ We've invited the Wongs to dinner.  
One can say 'the Wongs' but 'the Wong family' has no 's'.

✗ Hong Kong is a famous port in the world. [351]

✓ Hong Kong is a famous port.  
Hong Kong is a world-famous port.  
Placing 'in the world' after 'port' makes one wonder where else the ports could be – on the moon? on Venus? It is often unnecessary but if 'world' is to be used, it should be placed near 'famous', as 'world-famous'.  
'In the world' can be used with the superlative:  
Hong Kong is the most famous port in the world.

fare

✗ The Cross Harbour Tunnel fare may rise soon. [67]  
✓ The Cross Harbour Tunnel toll may rise soon.  
The amount of money charged to use a tunnel, bridge, highway etc is a 'toll'.

favour

✗ This is my favour TV programme. [139]  
✓ This is my favourite TV programme.  
'Favour' is a verb or noun; the adjective in this sense is 'favourite'.

favourable

1 ✗ This is my favourable TV programme. [23]  
This is my favourite TV programme.

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'Favourable' is an adjective but it means 'helpful' or 'approving', e.g.:  
✓ The TV programme had a favourable review in the newspaper.

2 ✗ It's a favourable place to visit. [265]  
✓ It's a place worth visiting.  
✓ It's a favourable time to visit as the weather is good.

✓ Tennis is my most favourite sport. [117]  
Tennis is my favourite sport.

'Favourite' means 'the one(s) liked most', so cannot be used with 'most'. There can, however, be more than one favourite, i.e. liked equally but more than all others:

✓ My favourite sports are tennis, swimming and football.

✗ I am fear of dogs. [140]  
✓ I am afraid of dogs.  
'Fear' is a verb or noun; the adjective is 'afraid'.

✗ The bus fee is a lot less than the taxi fee. [67]  
✓ The bus fare is a lot less than the taxi fare.

'Fares' are charged for public transport, including planes, while 'fees' are charged by doctors, lawyers, schools etc and for membership of associations, government licences etc. The Cantonese 費 is used for fees and fares.

✗ I go to school on feet. [199]  
✓ I go to school on foot.  
'Feet' is quite logical, but the fixed expression uses the singular: 'on foot'.

✗ There were a few people in the market, so the hawkers took a rest. [180]  
✓ There were few people in the market, so the hawkers took a rest.  
'A few' means 'several/a small number of' in the positive sense (so the

fear

fee

feet

few

★ favourite

★



hawkers would want to do business) while 'few' means 'not many' in the negative sense (so the hawkers can rest before more people come).

- ✓ Compare these:  
 ✓ We have had **few** customers all day. (negative)  
 ✓ There are **a few** customers waiting to be served. (positive)

## fiction

- ✓ I borrowed a **fiction** from the library. [68]  
 ✓ I borrowed a **novel** from the library.  
 'Fiction' is the general category of books which are stories. One particular book-length story is a 'novel'.

## find

- 1 ✗ He can't come yet, he's still **finding** his book. [69]  
 ✓ He can't come yet, he's still **looking for** his book.  
 'Find' is the equivalent of 搵到 while 搵 by itself means 'to look for'.  
 2 ✗ I could not **found** it. [272]  
 ✓ I could not **find** it.  
 The simple past tense is already expressed in 'could' so it should not be used again in 'find' (which is infinitive).

## fire

- ✗ A fire **happened** in Hung Hom yesterday. [352]  
 ✓ A fire **broke out** in Hung Hom yesterday.  
 'Happen' is too weak a word; 'break out' is usual when 'fire' is the subject.

## first time

- ✗ This is my **first time** to travel by plane. [320]  
 ✓ This is **the first time** I have travelled by plane.  
 In Cantonese 我第一次 can be followed directly by a verb but in English it must be 'the first time'

## flesh

✗ In the country we can breathe **flesh** air. [95]



- ✓ In the country we can breathe **fresh** air.  
 'Flesh' is raw meat! This mistake may come from pronouncing the 'r' of 'fresh' like an 'l'.

## floor

- ✗ As she was walking in the street she suddenly fell on the **floor**. [70]  
 ✓ As she was walking in the street she suddenly fell on the **ground**.  
 In Cantonese 地 can be used both indoors and outdoors while English uses 'ground' outdoors and 'floor' indoors.

## food

- ✗ We bought **many foods** at the supermarket. [174]  
 ✓ We bought **a lot of food** at the supermarket.  
 'Food' is usually uncountable (and so singular) except for particular types of food, e.g. 'health foods'.

## for

- 1 ✗ I have been **leaving** Hong Kong for three years. [299]



- ✓ I **left** Hong Kong three years ago.  
 ✓ I **have been away from** Hong Kong for three years.  
 'For' refers to the time spent on the action indicated by the verb. The three years were obviously not spent leaving, they were spent being away from Hong Kong. 'Ago' is used when the action in the verb is not still happening, as it refers to a single time in the past.

- 2 ✗ I **am** a secretary for five years. [299]  
 ✓ I **have been** a secretary for five years.  
 If the person is still a secretary, the present perfect tense should be used. If the person is no longer a secretary, the simple past tense should be used:  
 ✓ I **was** a secretary for five years.  
 3 ✗ I **have been** to China for several times. [220]  
 ✓ I **have been** to China **several times**.  
 'For' is not used for the number of times something happens, just for the length of time an action takes.

## for example

- 1 ✗ There are many types of transport, for examples: bus, mini-bus, MTR, KCR, tram and taxi. [211]  
 ✓ There are many types of transport, **for example**: bus, mini-bus, MTR, KCR, tram and taxi.

Even though more than one example is given, 'example' stays singular.

- 2 ✗ I play many sports. For example, basketball, soccer and tennis. [342]  
 I play many sports, **for example**: basketball, soccer and tennis.  
 A list of nouns is not a sentence, so in this case 'for example' should be joined to the previous sentence. 'For example' can begin a new sentence when it is followed by at least a subject and verb:  
 ✓ Steve is very superstitious. **For example**, he will never walk under a ladder.

## for instance

See FOR EXAMPLE. The same applies.

## foul language

- ✗ He spoke **foul** languages. [353]



**He used bad language.**  
 'Language' is only plural when it refers to different languages. 'Foul' is a strong word and can be used for really obscene language, but 'bad language' is a more common expression for swearing. And the verb is generally 'use'.

## friend

- ✗ Betty met Jane at university and soon made **friend** with her. [200]  
 ✓ Betty met Jane at university and soon



instead of the definite 'something/ someone etc'.

- 3 ☒ ~~It is hardly to say who will win.~~ [157]  
☒ ~~It is hard to say who will win.~~  
 'Hardly' is an adverb. 'It is' must be followed by an adjective or a noun/pronoun, in this case the adjective 'hard' meaning 'difficult'.

home

- 1 ☒ ~~Have many people in Central.~~ [291]  
☒ ~~There are many people in Central.~~  
☒ ~~There had a sudden thunderstorm.~~  
☒ ~~There was a sudden thunderstorm.~~  
 The Cantonese 有 often means 'there is', 'there are' etc in English, not 'have'.  
 2 ☒ ~~I had not the right coins for the bus fare.~~ [310]  
☒ ~~I didn't have the right coins for the bus fare.~~  
 When the main verb is 'have', its negative uses 'do'.  
 3 ☒ ~~I have no this book.~~ [31]  
☒ ~~I do not have this book.~~

homework

- 1 ☒ ~~I have a lot of homeworks tonight.~~ [170]  
☒ ~~I have a lot of homework tonight.~~  
 'Homework' is never plural and never takes 'a'.  
 2 ☒ ~~Tonight I must study my homework.~~ [25]  
☒ ~~Tonight I must do my homework.~~  
☒ ~~Tonight I must study.~~  
 'Homework' is particular exercises given by a teacher for students to do, while 'study' is more general – revising lessons, reading textbooks etc. The Cantonese expression combining these two different activities 溫習功課 should be translated as 'do homework and study'.

have

health

healthy

here

- ☒ ~~I wish you a good health.~~ [16]  
☒ ~~I wish you good health.~~  
 'Health' is uncountable, so cannot take 'a'.  
☒ ~~Bean curd is very good for our healthy.~~ [14]  
☒ ~~Bean curd is very good for our health.~~  
 'Healthy' is the adjective, whereas the noun 'health' is needed here.  
 1 ☒ ~~The teacher said, 'Please come to here.'~~ [29]  
☒ ~~The teacher said, 'Please come here.'~~  
 'Here' and 'there' are not normally preceded by 'to'.  
 2 ☒ ~~Here is very noisy.~~ [29]  
☒ ~~It is very noisy here.~~  
 'Here' cannot be used like the name of a place; it is an adverb, showing where the action of the verb takes place. 'Here' is only used before the verb 'is/ are' when followed by a noun,

how

hundred

- ☒ ~~When the fire started I didn't know how to do.~~ [304]  
☒ ~~When the fire started I didn't know what to do.~~  
 The Cantonese 唔知點算 means 'not know what to do'. 'How' must be followed by something definite, e.g. 'how to put it out'.  
☒ ~~There were a hundred of passengers on the plane.~~ [224]  
☒ ~~There were a hundred passengers on the plane.~~  
 Although one says 'hundreds of', there is no 'of' with 'a hundred', 'two hundred' etc.  
☒ ~~I and my mother went shopping.~~ [110]  
☒ ~~My mother and I went shopping.~~  
 Other people should come before oneself.

importance

impression

information

interfere

introduce

- ☒ ~~Maylee has a very importance job.~~ [143]  
☒ ~~Maylee has a very important job.~~  
 'Importance' is the noun; the adjective ends with a 't'.

- 1 ☒ ~~The singer gave an impression to the audience.~~ [356]  
☒ ~~The singer made a big impression on the audience.~~  
 To 'make an impression on' people is to influence their minds or feelings.  
 2 ☒ ~~I had a deep impression of that actor.~~  
☒ ~~I was deeply impressed by that actor.~~  
 The expression is to 'be impressed by' someone.

- ☒ ~~She got many informations before the journey.~~ [16]  
☒ ~~She got a lot of information before the journey.~~  
 'Information' is uncountable, so cannot be plural.

- ☒ ~~Bill interfered the arrangements for Jim's party.~~ [24]  
☒ ~~Bill interfered with the arrangements for Jim's party.~~  
 The verb 'interfere' never takes a direct object. One interferes 'in' someone's affairs, 'between' people and 'with' plans or equipment.

- ☒ ~~After I had met my cousin at the airport, he introduced his life in Canada.~~ [26]  
☒ ~~After I had met my cousin at the airport, he told me about his life in Canada.~~  
 'Introduce' is used much less in English than 介紹 in Cantonese. It means bringing something in for the first time, especially helping two people get to know each other. It does not mean describing or talking about something.

join

know

- ☒ ~~There are trams on Hong Kong island.~~  
 'On' is the preposition often used for an island; one lives 'in' Kowloon but 'on' Hong Kong island.

- ☒ ~~On Sports Day, Sue joined the 400-metre race.~~ [244]  
☒ ~~On Sports Day, Sue entered the 400-metre race.~~  
☒ ~~At the picnic, Garry joined many activities.~~  
☒ ~~At the picnic, Garry joined in many activities.~~  
☒ ~~Mr Chan was accepted to join in the club.~~  
☒ ~~Mr Chan was accepted to join the club.~~  
 In all three examples, 參加 can be used in the Cantonese. However, in English one **joins** a club, the army, the police etc; **enters** a race or competition; **joins in** an activity; and **takes part in** a game or activity.

- 1 ☒ ~~He didn't go into the water because he didn't know swimming.~~ [305]  
☒ ~~He didn't go into the water because he didn't know how to swim.~~  
 The Cantonese is simply 唔識游泳 but the English is 'not know how to'.  
 2 ☒ ~~At the barbecue I knew many new friends.~~ [27]  
☒ ~~At the barbecue I made many new friends.~~  
 'Knowing' a friend takes time; on the first occasion one 'makes a friend', 'meets people' or 'gets to know people'.  
 3 ☒ ~~As we all know that Hong Kong waters are polluted.~~ [341]  
☒ ~~As we all know, Hong Kong waters are polluted.~~  
 'As we all know' can introduce a simple statement, forming a sentence. When 'that' is added it gives 'as' its different meaning of 'since' and a further clause is needed to complete a

island

- ☒ ~~There are trams in Hong Kong island.~~ [2]

## knowledge

- ✓ sentence, e.g.:  
 ✓ As we all know that Hong Kong waters are polluted, we should campaign for something to be done about it.

- 1 ✗ At school I ~~learn~~ a lot of knowledge. [71]  
 ✓ At school I **gained** a lot of knowledge. The Cantonese 學到知識 may lead to the use of 'learn' here, but in English 'learn' is too narrow a word for gaining something as broad as knowledge. Likewise:  
 ✗ She ~~taught~~ me a lot of knowledge.  
 ✓ She **taught** me **many things**.  
 ✓ She **helped** me **gain** a lot of knowledge.  
 2 ✗ At university, she ~~improved~~ her knowledge. [72]  
 ✓ At university, she **broadened** her knowledge. Similarly, knowledge is broadened, increased or extended rather than 'improved'.  
 3 ✗ Our teacher has a lot of ~~knowledges~~. [16]  
 ✓ Our teacher has a lot of **knowledge**. 'Knowledge' is uncountable, so can never be plural.

## late

- 2 ✗ Last morning I slept in quite late. [322]  
 ✓ **Yesterday morning** I slept in quite late. 'Last night' is correct, but other expressions don't use 'last': 'yesterday evening', 'yesterday afternoon' and 'yesterday morning'.  
 3 See AT LAST.  
 1 ✗ The buses were full, so I was ~~late for~~ one hour. [111]  
 ✓ The buses were full, so I was **one hour late**. The amount of time goes before 'late' in English but after it in Cantonese.  
 2 ✗ 'I'm sorry for my late.'  
 ✓ 'I'm sorry for **being late/coming late**'. 'Late' is not a noun; it is an adverb or adjective.  
 3 ✗ I had never ~~late~~ for school before. [285]  
 ✓ I have never **been late** for school before. Similarly, 'late' is not a verb.  
 ✗ I was ~~laying~~ on my bed. [297]



- ✓ I was **lying** on my bed.  
 ✓ I **lay** on my bed. The different verbs 'lie' and 'lay' are often confused because some of their forms are similar. 'Lie' has a present participle 'lying' and a simple past 'lay' (the past participle 'lain' is not so common). 'Lay' has a present participle 'laying', and the simple past and past participle are the same, 'laid'. It means to 'put down', including laying eggs!  
 ✓ The children **laid** the table before the meal. (meaning they put down the plates, knives, forks etc) [298]

## lack

- 1 ✗ She was ~~lack of~~ parental care. [144]  
 ✓ She **lacked** parental care. 'Lack' is a normal verb taking a direct object but it is often confused with the noun in the expression 'a lack of'.  
 2 ✗ Hong Kong ~~lack of~~ university places for all its good students. [24]  
 ✓ Hong Kong **lacks** university places for all its good students.  
 ✓ **There is a lack of** university places in Hong Kong for all its good students. Again, 'lack' should be used as a normal verb with a direct object as in the first correct example, or as a noun in the second correct example.

## last

- 1 ✗ On ~~last~~ Sunday, we went to Shek O. [12]  
 ✓ **Last Sunday**, we went to Shek O. 'On Sunday' is correct but 'last Sunday' and 'next Sunday' do not take

**Proofreading:** In each of the following questions, there is one or no mistake. For each question, you may underline one word and write another word above it to replace it; or put a ^ between two words and write down an additional word above the ^; or cross out one redundant word. If there is no mistake, put a ✓ on the far right.

- During the flag-raising ceremony, the teacher told us to put our bags on the floor.
- The teacher gave the student go to the toilet.
- This is the first time I have got in a plane, so I am a bit frightened.
- Jerry is friend with Tom.
- The student lacks of confidence, although he has studied very hard in the past two years for HKCEE.
- When the explosion was happened last night, I was doing my homework.
- On Sundays, have a lot of people like lying on that grassland to enjoy the sunlight.